



MassHealth Pediatric Behavioral Health Medication Initiative

BACKGROUND

The Pediatric Behavioral Health Medication Initiative proactively requires prior authorization for pediatric members (generally members less than 18 years of age) for certain behavioral health medication classes and/or specific medication combinations (i.e., polypharmacy) that have limited evidence for safety and efficacy in the pediatric population.

As part of this initiative, the following situations will require a prior authorization:

1. **Behavioral health medication polypharmacy:** (i.e., α_2 agonists, antidepressants, antipsychotics, armodafinil, atomoxetine, benzodiazepines, buspirone, cerebral stimulants, donepezil, hypnotic agents, memantine, meprobamate, modafinil, mood stabilizers [agents considered to be used only for seizure diagnoses are not included], naltrexone, prazosin, viloxazine, and xanomeline/trospium) filled within a 45-day period for members less than 18 years of age:
 - Pharmacy claims for 4 or more behavioral health medications **if one of the following is included:** an antipsychotic, a benzodiazepine, divalproex/valproate, lithium, or a tricyclic antidepressant
 - Pharmacy claims for 5 or more behavioral health medications (regardless of the medications included)
2. **Antipsychotic polypharmacy:** overlapping pharmacy claims for two or more antipsychotics for at least 60 days within a 90-day period for members less than 18 years of age;
3. **Antidepressant polypharmacy:** overlapping pharmacy claims for two or more antidepressants for at least 60 days within a 90-day period for members less than 18 years of age;
4. **Cerebral stimulant polypharmacy:** overlapping pharmacy claims for two or more cerebral stimulants (immediate-release and extended-release formulations of the same chemical entity are counted as one) for at least 60 days within a 90-day period for members less than 18 years of age;
5. **Mood stabilizer polypharmacy:** overlapping pharmacy claims for three or more mood stabilizers (agents considered to be used only for seizure diagnoses are not included) for at least 60 days within a 90-day period for members less than 18 years of age;
6. **Benzodiazepine polypharmacy:** overlapping pharmacy claims for two or more benzodiazepines (hypnotic benzodiazepine agents, clobazam, nasal and rectal diazepam, and nasal midazolam are not included) for at least 60 days within a 90-day period for members less than 18 years of age;
7. **Antipsychotic** pharmacy claim for members less than ten years of age;
8. **Antidepressant, armodafinil, atomoxetine, benzodiazepine, buspirone, donepezil, hypnotic, memantine, meprobamate, modafinil, mood stabilizer (agents considered to be used only for seizure diagnoses are not included), naltrexone, prazosin, viloxazine, or xanomeline/trospium** pharmacy claim for members less than six years of age;
9. **α_2 agonist or cerebral stimulant** pharmacy claim for members less than three years of age.

The reference table below lists the behavioral health medications included in the Pediatric Behavioral Health Medication Initiative. Further information on the prior authorization requirements, including approval criteria, can be found within the MassHealth Drug List at www.mass.gov/druglist.

Pediatric Behavioral Health Medication Initiative Medication List¹

Antidepressants		Mood Stabilizers	
amitriptyline	levomilnacipran	carbamazepine	oxcarbazepine
amoxapine	mirtazapine	divalproex	pregabalin
bupropion	nefazodone	gabapentin	topiramate
citalopram	nortriptyline	lamotrigine	valproic acid
clomipramine	paroxetine	Antianxiety Agents	lithium
desipramine	phenelzine		
desvenlafaxine	protriptyline		
dextromethorphan/bupropion	selegiline ²		
doxepin	sertraline		
duloxetine	tranylcypromine		
escitalopram	trazodone		
esketamine	trimipramine		
fluoxetine	venlafaxine		
fluvoxamine	vilazodone		
imipramine	vortioxetine		
isocarboxazid	zuranolone		
Antipsychotics		Hypnotics	
aripiprazole	olanzapine/fluoxetine	daridorexant	quazepam
asenapine	olanzapine/samidorphan	doxepin ⁴	suvorexant
brexpiprazole	paliperidone	estazolam	temazepam
cariprazine	perphenazine	eszopiclone	triazolam
chlorpromazine	perphenazine/amitriptyline	flurazepam	zaleplon
clozapine	pimozide	lemborexant	zolpidem
fluphenazine	quetiapine	Alpha ₂ Agonists	
haloperidol	risperidone	clonidine	guanfacine
iloperidone	thioridazine	Stimulants	
loxapine	thiothixene	amphetamine	lisdexamfetamine
lumateperone	trifluoperazine	dexmethylphenidate	methamphetamine
lurasidone	xanomeline/trospium	dextroamphetamine	methylphenidate
molindone	ziprasidone	dextroamphetamine/ amphetamine	serdexmethylphenidate/ dexmethylphenidate
olanzapine		Miscellaneous	
		armodafinil	modafinil
		atomoxetine	naltrexone ⁵
		donepezil	prazosin
		memantine	viloxazine

¹Short-acting intramuscular injectable and intravenous formulations are excluded from the Pediatric Behavioral Health Medication Initiative requirements.

²Emsam (selegiline) is the only selegiline formulation included in the Pediatric Behavioral Health Medication Initiative.

³Nasal and rectal diazepam and nasal midazolam formulations are excluded from the Pediatric Behavioral Health Medication Initiative requirements.

⁴Doxepin tablet is classified as a hypnotic agent and the Pediatric Behavioral Health Medication Initiative requirements for antidepressants do not apply. Pediatric Behavioral Health Medication Initiative requirements for hypnotics apply.

⁵Vivitrol (naltrexone injection) is excluded from the Pediatric Behavioral Health Medication Initiative requirements.